



Restroom and Drinking Water Under lens: India's Sanitation Crisis

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Millions in India still face a stark daily reality: unsafe drinking water and poorly maintained public restrooms. For students, this is not just a sanitation issue — it affects health, dignity, and the chance to learn and thrive.

India's Drinking Water Crisis

India

Unsafe Water Access

Millions of people across India still rely on unsafe or unreliable drinking water sources, especially in rural and peri-urban communities.

Contamination

Widespread Pollution

nitrate, and microbial contamination in many districts.
Groundwater and local supply systems are affected by fluoride, arsenic,



India's Public Restroom Crisis

Many Lack Clean Public Toilets

Across cities and transit hubs, access to clean, usable public toilets remains limited and uneven.

15.3 Million People

In India still practice open defecation, according to the latest WHO/UNICEF estimates.

Poor Maintenance

Existing facilities are often broken, unstaffed, or out of service, leaving toilets unusable when people need them most.

Hygiene Risks

Unsafe water, clogged drains, bad odors, and missing soap or handwashing stations make public restrooms a health hazard.

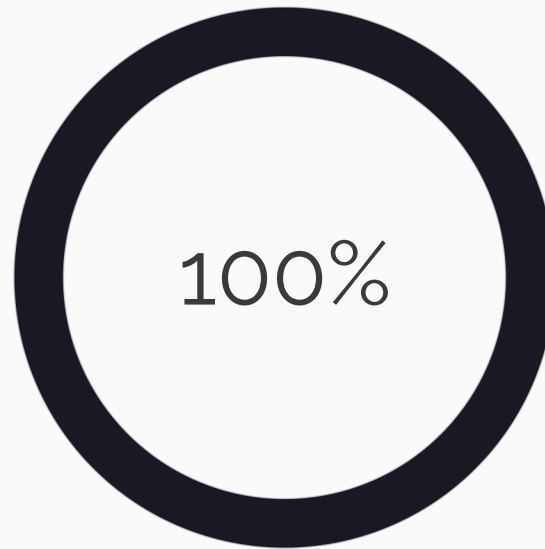


What Happens When Water Isn't Safe

The Human Cost in India

In India, unsafe drinking water and poor public sanitation often reinforce each other — spreading disease through homes, schools, streets, and shared toilets. Together, they increase infections, worsen malnutrition, and put children under 5 at the highest risk.

- **Diarrhea, cholera, typhoid, hepatitis A, and dysentery** are common waterborne diseases linked to unsafe water and inadequate sanitation
- **Children under 5** face the greatest danger, with repeated infections contributing to dehydration, stunting, and preventable deaths
- **Poor restroom conditions** and open defecation contaminate water sources, allowing disease to spread back into the community
- **1.5 million+** deaths each year in India are linked to unsafe water, sanitation, and hygiene-related diseases
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Compounding Risk

Unsafe water and poor sanitation create a cycle of repeated infection, making recovery harder and raising mortality risk.

Who Suffers Most in India



Rural vs. Urban India

Rural households are far more likely to face unsafe water and poor toilet access, while many urban slums still rely on shared or missing restrooms. In both settings, distance, crowding, and weak infrastructure raise disease risk.



Low-Income Communities

Families with the fewest resources are most exposed to contaminated water and inadequate sanitation. The burden is heaviest where public services are underfunded and overcrowded.



Women & Girls in India

Women and girls often spend hours collecting water and searching for safe, private restrooms. This reduces time for school, work, and safety, and increases their vulnerability every day.

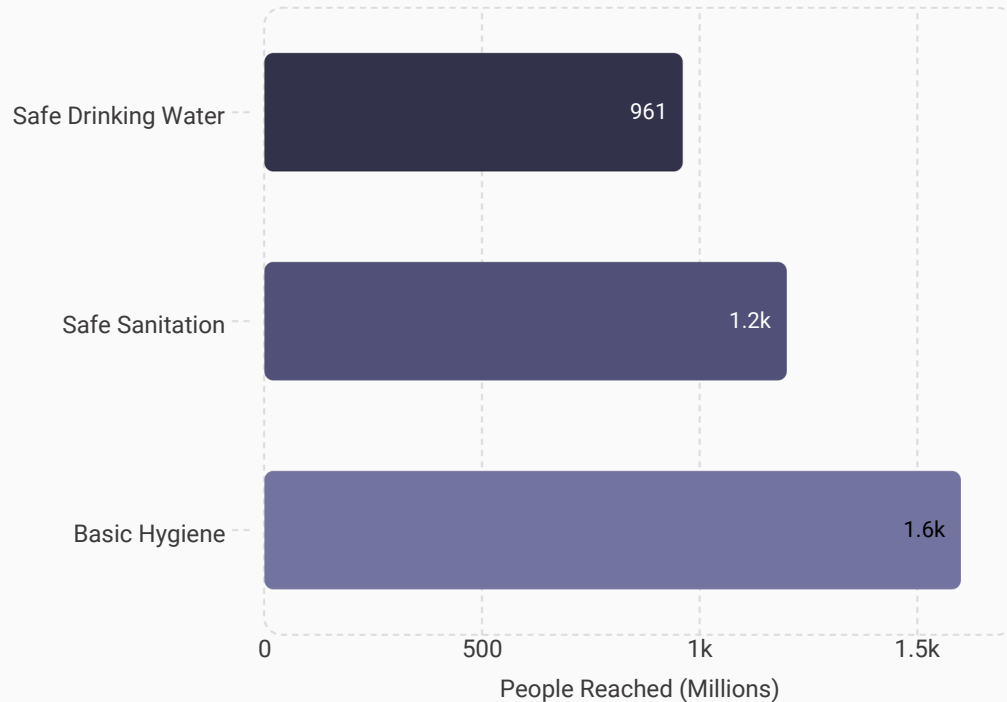


Most-Affected Regions

Need is especially severe in parts of Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Jharkhand, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, and the urban informal settlements around major cities where water and sanitation access remain inconsistent.

India's Progress Since 2015

Milestone



Gains Since 2015

India has made major strides since 2015. Millions of households have gained access to safer drinking water through initiatives to expand rural and urban supply, while the **Swachh Bharat Mission** helped drive large-scale toilet construction and expand sanitation coverage across the country.

These gains have improved daily life and public health, but progress is uneven. Some communities still face unreliable water supply, and many toilets need consistent water, maintenance, and sustained use to deliver lasting sanitation benefits.



The Economic Case for Action in India



Healthcare Costs from Poor Water

Poor water quality and sanitation drive preventable illness, increasing household and public healthcare spending in India and adding pressure to already strained health systems.



Lost Productivity and School Time

Waterborne disease keeps adults out of work and children out of class, reducing earnings, learning outcomes, and long-term workforce productivity across India.



GDP Gains from Better Water

Investing in safe water and sanitation can raise productivity, lower medical costs, and improve education – creating a stronger foundation for India's economic growth.

What You Can Do



Start in Your Community

Students in India can help improve **drinking water safety** and **public restroom cleanliness** by taking action at home, in school, and in their neighborhoods.

- Support Local NGOs
Volunteer with or donate to Indian NGOs working on clean water, sanitation, toilet maintenance, and hygiene education in underserved communities.
 - Lead Community Initiatives
Organize school drives, neighborhood clean-ups, water-testing campaigns, and awareness programs for safer drinking water and cleaner public restrooms.
 - Advocate for Better Infrastructure
Ask local officials and school leaders to improve water treatment, fix broken taps, add handwashing stations, and maintain public toilets regularly.
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-  Practice Personal Responsibility
Use water carefully, report unsafe taps or dirty toilets, wash hands properly, and encourage friends and family to keep facilities clean.

Sources

- WHO India
- Ministry of Jal Shakti, Government of India
- Swachh Bharat Mission – Government of India
- Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB), India
- NITI Aayog
- UNICEF India
- WaterAid India
- Centre for Science and Environment (CSE)